

SANJIVANI



WRITTEN BY
ISHAAN KR. SINGH

SANJIVANI

✦ Opening Lines

Kuch log duniya mein aate hain toh duniya unka swagat karti hai.

Aur kuch log aate hain... toh duniya unhe dekhti tak nahi.

Par dekhne aur samajhne mein fark hota hai.

Chapter 1: Break of expectations

Screen ki neeli roshni Om ke chehre par pad rahi thi. Baaki kamrei mei andhera tha — parde khiche hue, ceiling fan dheere-dheere ghoom raha tha, aur earphones se online coaching ki awaaz aa rahi thi. Chemistry ka last lecture tha. Teacher screen par equations likh raha tha, par Om ki ek aankh hamesha browser ke us doosre tab par tiki thi — jahan CBSE result ki website baar baar "Error 503" dikha rahi thi.

Class khatam hui. Earphones nikaale. Kamre mein ek ajeeb si khamoshi chhayi.

Om ne ek baar phir F5 dabaya.

"Website abhi bhi load nahi ho rahi," usne khud se kaha, jaise awaaz nikaalne se waqt tez ho jaaye!

Tabhi phone ka screen chala. Papa ka call aaya

"Haan Papa?"

"Arre, news mein dikha raha hai result aa gaya. Tera bhi aagya hoga — check kar jaldi."

Om ne turant doosre haath se refresh dabaya. Is baar website khul gayi. Roll number daala, date of birth daali, aur ek gehri saans li.

80.4%

Wo ek pal bas dekhta raha. Na dil baitha, na uski taraf se koi asmaan se tare toote. Ek theek-thaak si khushi thi — wahi jo milti hai jab koi cheez expect ke aas-paas ho.

"Papa... 80% aaye hain."

"Accha. Theek hai."

Bas itna. Call khatam.

Om ne phone haath mein pakde rakha kuch der. Usne socha — shayad Papa office mein hain, isliye zyada bol nahi paye. Shayad shaam ko ghar aayenge toh mithai laayenge. **Shayad.**

Mummy ko bataya toh seedha phone kaan se laga liya unhone.

"Haan didi, 82% aaye hain Om ke... haan haan bohot achhe hain... main bhi keh rahi thi na ye ladka mehnat karta hai..."

Om wahan khada sunta raha. 82. Usne toh 80 bola tha. Par Mummy ki awaaz mein jo garv tha, wo unke liye tha — logon ke liye — Om ke liye nahi.

Wo chupchap apne kamre mein wapas aa gaya.

Raat ke nau baje Papa ghar aaye. Haath mein koi dabba nahi tha. Chehre par thakan thi — wahi rozana wali.

Om sofa par baitha tha. Usne upar dekha.

"Beta, sun — tu jaanta hai teri percentage 80 hai. Dusre schools science ke liye 85% maang rahe hain. Wahan jaayega toh naya mahaul, naye kharche — pata nahi kaisa ho. Iss school mein hi reh, yahan adjustment ho jaayegi."

Om ne ek pal kuch nahi kaha. Uske andar ek tees uthti rahi — na gusse ki, na dukh ki — bas ek anjaani si kasak.

"Theek hai Papa. Usi school se karunga."

"Theek hai."

Aur bas. Koi "tu kar sakta hai," koi "hum hain na tere saath" nahi. Jaise ye ek logistical problem thi, emotional moment nahi.

Om apne kamre mein aaya aur darwaza band kar liya. Usne apni hatheli dekhi. Koi mithai nahi aayi thi.

Main khush hona chahta tha. Kya ye itna mushkil tha?

Din beet-te gaye — ek ke baad ek, jaise assembly line par nikalta koi product.

Subah uthao. School. Wapas aao. Coaching. Khana. Padhai. So jao.

Baar baar. Roz.

Bahar jaana chahta toh Mummy rok deti — "Maholl theek nahi hai, kya zaroorat hai?" Doston ke saath ghumna chahte ho toh — "Pehle settle ho jao, phir sab hoga." Koi nayi jagah dekhne ki baat karta toh — "Abhi padhai pe dhyan do."

Ek din Om ne Mummy se pucha, "Mummy, agar kisi gaadi mein accident ho jaye, toh kya wo hamesha ke liye gaadi mein baithna band kar deta hai?"

Mummy ne uski taraf ek pal dekha aur baat badal di.

Om samajh gaya. Jawab nahi milega.

Care aur overcare mein fark hota hai. Ek tumhe thamta hai, doosra tumhe rok leta hai. Par ye baat main unhe kaise samjhaun?

Phir aayi woh raat.

Koi khaas wajah nahi thi. Koi bada jhagda nahi hua tha, koi buri khabar nahi aayi thi. Bas ek aam raat thi — usi aam zindagi ki — jo Om ko ab andar se khaali karti ja rahi thi.

Om apne kamre mein leta hua tha. Aankhein chhatt par tiki thi, jahan pankha apni wahi purani, thakaan bhari chal chal raha tha — bina ruke, bina kisi maqsad ke, bas ghoomta raha.

Bilkul mere jaisa, Om ne socha.

Woh bhi toh bas ghoom raha tha — school, coaching, ghar, school, coaching, ghar. Chakkar pe chakkar. Koi manzil nahi, koi destination nahi. Bas ek tay shuda daayra tha, jisme woh roz subah dakhil hota tha aur raat ko wahan se nikalkar so jaata tha.

Kya yahi zindagi hai? Kya yahi rehega hamesha?

Thakaan thi — par uss tarah ki nahi jo neend se jaati hai. Ye andar ki thakaan thi. Wo thakaan jo tab aati hai jab insaan koshish karte karte thak jaata hai... aur phir bhi kuch nahi badalta.

Main useless hoon, usne socha. *Nahi — main useless nahi hoon. Main bas... hoon. Yahan hoon. Bas itna hi.*

Aur kisi tarah, us raat, ye "bas itna hi" bahut zyada bhari baat lag rahi thi.

"Om! Khana lag gaya, aa jao!"

Mummy ki awaaz aayi. Om ne ek gehri saans li, uthke darwaza khola aur bahar aa gaya. Kya karta.

Dining table par, TV chal raha thi. Om ne plate mein roti todna shuru kiya, adh mann se.

Tabhi anchor ki awaaz tez ho gayi. Screen par San Francisco ka aasmaan dikha — laal aur kaala, upar ek vishalkay alien ship mandra rahi thi. Breaking news ki red strip chal rahi thi. Poori duniya saans rok ke dekh rahi thi.

Om ki nigaah TV par gayi.

Aur phir screen par ek stage dikha. Hazaron log the. Ek anchor ne microphone thama aur bola:

"Ladies and gentlemen, please welcome — Ishaan Kumar Singh — the man who saved us from the threat of humanity's extinction!"

Aur phir Ishaan stage par aaya — wahi thaka hua chehra, wahi saadgi — aur usne microphone pakda. woh ek pal ruka. Poori duniya khamosh ho gayi.

"Main bhi ek kamre mein band tha. Mere paas bahar jaane ki, bolne ki, jeene ki azaadi nahi thi. Par maine ek baat seekhi — azaadi maangi nahi jaati. Azaadi kamayi jaati hai. Aur azaadi ki sirf ek currency hai — kamyabi."

Om ka haath ruk gaya. Roti adhi tooti reh gayi.

Pankha ghoom raha tha. Daayra chal raha tha. Par us ek line ne kuch tod diya tha — ya shayad kuch jod diya tha — Om ke andar.

Azaadi ki sirf ek currency hai — kamyabi.

Om ne plate side mein rakhi. Uthke apne kamre mein gaya. Darwaza band kiya.

Aur pehli baar mahino mein, us pankhe ko dekhte hue Om ke chehre par ek alag expression tha — thakaan nahi, ek decision.

Waste nahi. Abhi nahi. Pehle kamyab hona padega.



Chapter 2: 1st Priority

Uss raat ke baad Om wahi nahi raha.

Ishaan ki wo line — "Azaadi ki sirf ek currency hai — kamyabi" — ab sirf ek quote nahi thi. Wo Om ke dimaag ki deewar par likhi ek ibarat ban chuki thi. Subah uthta toh wo line. Raat ko sota toh wo line. School mein lecture sunte hue, coaching mein equations dekhte hue — har jagah wahi ek awaaz.

Kamyab hona padega. Kamyab hona padega. Kamyab hona padega.

Usne NEET ki taiyari shuru kar di. Properly. Openly. Usne ghar mein bata diya, coaching mein bata diya. Koi drama nahi tha, koi announcement nahi thi — bas ek faisla tha jo ho chuka tha. Roz raat ko, jab ghar mein sab so jaate, wo ghanton padhta. NEET guide, Biology diagrams, Physics problems — sab ek saath.

Ishaan uska idol ban chuka tha. Wo Ishaan ke baare mein jitna padh sakta, padhta. Uske interviews, uski story, SAHAY ka concept — sab kuch. Aur jitna padhta, utna zyada yakeen hota ki agar ek 'invisible' ladka ye kar sakta hai, toh Om kyun nahi?

Main bhi karunga. Zaroor karunga.

School mein Om ki zindagi ka ek alag rang tha.

Baaki duniya ke liye Om ek 'quiet' ladka tha — jo class mein peechhe baithta tha, zyada shor nahi karta tha. Par jo log use jaante the, unke liye wo kuch aur tha.

Unka group paanch logon ka tha.

Om. Gauri. Rupkatha — (Bengali thi, Kolkata se aayi thi do saal pehle, uski Hindi mein kabhi kabhi Bengali ke lafz ghus aate the jo sab ko hasaate the). **Mihir** — (MP ka tha, bilkul seedha-saadha, jo baat karta seedha karta). Aur **Tanish** — (jo class mein marks ke mamle mein sabse peeche tha, par jiske jokes se canteen mein bhi log hans dete the).

Rupkatha aur Mihir ek doosre ko pasand karte the — ye poori class jaanti thi, sirf wo dono jaanne se inkaar karte the. Jab bhi unhe koi ek saath dekhta, toh Mihir ka chehra laal ho jaata aur Rupkatha apne baal theek karne lagti,

Tanish padhai mein kamzor tha. Par Om ne kabhi use akela nahi chhodha. Roz lunch break mein wo Tanish ke saath baith ke use Physics samjhata — baar baar, naye tarike se, bina thake.

"Tu kyun karta hai meri itni help?" Tanish ne ek din pooch liya.

Om ne kandhe uchkaye. "Kyunki tu kar sakta hai. Tu bas ye jaanta nahi hai abhi."

Tanish ne ek pal Om ko dekha, phir apni copy mein jhank gaya. Kuch zyada kaha nahi. Par us din se uska dhyani thoda zyada lagta tha class mein.

Aur phir thi Gauri.

Gauri ke baare mein Om ke paas words nahi the — jo feel hota tha wo words mein aata hi nahi tha. Jab wo bolti thi toh Om ka dhyani lecture se hat jaata tha. Jab wo hasti thi toh Om ko lagta tha kamre ki roshni badh gayi. Jab wo kisi baat par seriously sochti thi — thodi si bhauhen tedi karke — toh Om ka dil ek beat miss kar deta tha.

Par usne kabhi kuch nahi kaha.

Gauri ne bhi kabhi kuch nahi kaha.

Dono jaante the. Dono anjaane bante rahe. Kyunki dosti toot jaane ka darr mohabbat se zyada bhari cheez hoti hai kabhi kabhi.

Phir ek din Gauri ne group mein announce kiya.

"Mere boards mein 90% aaye hain. Aur... mujhe Science City School mein admission mil gaya hai."

Ek pal ki khamoshi.

"GAURI!" Rupkatha ne chillate hue use hug kar liya. Mihir ne clap kiya. Tanish ne dramatic tarike se fainting ka natak kiya — "Itni topper dost thi meri aur main fail ho raha tha, dhokhebaz!"

Sab hans pade.

Om bhi hansa. Genuinely hansa — kyunki Gauri ki khushi real thi aur Om ko wo khushi achhi lagti thi.

Par andar kuch tha. Ek chubhan. Woh school doosri taraf tha. Matlab roz nahi milega. Matlab lunch break nahi. Matlab wo random baatein nahi — jo kabhi physics par hoti thi, kabhi kisi film par, kabhi kisi bhi baat par.

Wo chali jaayegi, Om ne socha. Aur main yahan rahoon ga. Waise hi.

Tanish ne idea diya. "Yaar, ek last meetup karte hain. Mall chalte hain sab — Gauri ke jaane se pehle."

Sabne ek doosre ki taraf dekha aur ek saath haan kar di.

Ghar se permission leni thi. Rupkatha ko mili. Mihir ko mili. Tanish ko toh poochna hi nahi padta tha — uske ghar mein itni formalities nahi thi. Gauri ko mili.

Om ki baari aayi.

Dinner ke baad, jab sab thoda relaxed the, Om ne carefully — bahut carefully — baat chhedhi.

"Maa, ek baat poochni thi."

"Haan bol."

"Hamare group ne socha hai ek baar mall jaayein. Gauri ka transfer ho raha hai na doosre school mein toh ek last meetup—"

"Kaun kaun jaayega?" Papa ne TV se nazar hataye bina pooch liya.

"Hum paanch dost hain — Om, Gauri, Rupkatha, Mihir, Tanish—"

"Ladkiyan bhi hain?" Mummy ne eyebrows uthaye.

"Haan, Gauri aur Rupkatha hain par woh dost hain, koi—"

"Nahi," Papa ne simply kaha. "Aajkal ka mahaul theek nahi hai. Dost bhi aajkal dhoka dete hain. Hum modern nahi hain — samajh le."

"Par Papa, ye sirf ek baar—"

"Maine keh diya na."

Om ne ek pal unke chehre ko dekha. Wahan koi gussa nahi tha, koi sakht nazar nahi thi — bas ek final faisla tha jo announce ho chuka tha. Debate ki jagah nahi thi.

Om wapas apne kamre mein aa gaya. Usne turant SUS GC khola.

"Yaar nahi aa sakta. Papa ne mana kar diya."

Replies aane lage turant —

Tanish: bhai 🤔🤔 Rupkatha: Om nooo 🤔 Mihir: yaar kuch jugaad? Gauri: ... theek hai. Miss karenge tujhe. 😞

Om ne phone neeche rakh diya. Screen band ho gayi.

Wo khidki ke paas baitha raha. Bahar aasmaan mein thodi der pehle ki dhoop ab dheere dheere dhal rahi thi. Wo soch raha tha ki abhi woh sab kisi food court mein baithe honge. Tanish koi bada sa burger kha raha hoga. Rupkatha aur Mihir kisi na kisi bahane ek doosre ke kareeb baith gaye honge. Gauri... Gauri shayad baar baar door ki taraf dekh rahi hogi.

SUS GC mein photos aane lage. Sab hanse hue. Sab saath. Ice cream, selfies, koi zabardasti banayi hui serious face wali photo — Tanish ki definitely.

Om ne ek ek photo dekhi. Phir phone band kar diya.

Rona nahi hai. Kisi ko bura mat kehne do.

Wo chup raha. Andar se — bilkul andar se — kuch tha jo daba hua tha, par uski jagah nahi thi.

Agle din school mein ek drill thi.

Sabko class mein se uthke ek line mein khada kiya gaya. Ek teacher ne aage se announce kiya: "Aaj hum ek simple activity karenge. Har student apna ek best friend choose karega aur uske paas jaake khada ho jaayega."

Class mein halchal machi. Log idhar udhar bhagne lage. Hassi, awaazein, "Arre tu mere paas aa!" wali cheekhen.

Om khada raha. Usne dekha — Mihir Rupkatha ki taraf bhaga. Rupkatha ne aankhein pheri, par woh muskurai bhi. Tanish ne apne ek aur dost ka haath pakda aur khich gaya.

Om ki baari aayi. Teacher ne uski taraf dekha, "Om — apna best friend choose karo."

Om ne ek pal socha. Phir dheere se muskuraya aur bola, "Miss, main ek kaise chunoon — mere toh bohot saare dost hain."

Teacher muskurai. Kuch bacche bhi hanse.

Om ne peeche mudkar dekha.

Wahan koi nahi tha.

Sabne apna ek dost chun liya tha. Sabke paas koi tha. Om ke paas sab the — aur isliye koi nahi tha. Wo kisi ki **1st priority** nahi tha. Wo sab ka dost tha — matlab kisi ka asli dost nahi tha.

Drill khatam hui. Om apni seat par wapas aa gaya. Usne apni copy kholi. Usne kuch likha nahi.

Ghar aakar usne apne notes dekhe — Chemistry, Physics, Biology — sab ek saath. Pages uthhte rahe, equations ghoomti rahi. Usne socha ek tablet le le, digital notes ke liye — zyada organized rahega, NEET ke liye bhi kaam aayega.

Papa darwaze ke bahar the. Om uthke unke paas gaya.

Par jaise hi unhe dekhne laga — thaki hui aankhein, kaam se lautte hue haath — Om ke gale mein kuch atak gaya.

80% mein satisfy nahi kar paya. Aur ab itna mehnga gift mangoon?

"Kuch tha?" Papa ne pooch liya.

"Nahi Papa. Kuch nahi."

Om wapas apne kamre mein aa gaya. Darwaza band kiya. Notes uthaye. Phir rakh diye.

Wo chhat ki taraf dekh raha tha. Pankha ghoom raha tha — wahi purana, wahi chakkar.

Par is baar Om ne pankhe ko waise nahi dekha jaise pehle dekhta tha — thakaan se, haare hue. Is baar usne use dekha aur ek cheez notice ki — **pankha kabhi ruka nahi. Chahe kuch bhi ho. Bas ghoomta raha.**

Shayad yahi karna hai. Bas ghoomte rehna. Rukna nahi.

Usne apni NEET guide nikali. Usne pehla page khola.

Aaj drill mein realize hua tha ki wo kisi ki **1st priority** nahi tha.

Toh ab ek hi raasta tha.

Khud ko itna kamyab banana ki duniya ke pass koi choice na rahe.



Chapter 3: Do We Really Need Freedom ?

Uss din ke baad Om badal gaya tha.

Par ye woh badlaav nahi tha jo dikhta hai — jo chehra sakht ho jaata hai, jo awaaz bhaari ho jaati hai. Ye andar ka badlaav tha. Khamosh. Dheere dheere. Jaise koi purani deewar hoti hai jo bahar se theek lagti hai par andar se khokhi ho chuki hoti hai.

Om ne smartwork shuru kiya.

Ishaan ka ek purana podcast tha — jisme usne ek baat kahi thi jo Om ke dimaag mein gad gayi thi:

"Log sochte hain kamyabi sirf hardwork se milti hai. Ye sabse badi misunderstanding hai. Hardwork ka koi substitute nahi — par akele hardwork se sirf thakaan milti hai. Kamyabi milti hai smartwork se. Sahi cheez, sahi waqt par, sahi tarike se."

Om ne wo podcast teen baar suna. Phir usne apna poora study pattern badal diya.

Usne pehle analysis ki — kaun se topics NEET mein sabse zyada baar aaye hain pichle das saalon mein. Kaun se chapters high weightage ke hain. Kaun se questions predictable hain.

Usne ek pattern map banaya — hath se, ek purani notebook mein — aur uske hisaab se apna schedule set kiya.

Sirf important cheezein. Sirf woh jo kaam aaye. Baki sab baad mein.

Aur sath hi sath — raat ko, jab sab so jaate — Om ek aur kaam karta tha.

Wo ek bio device ka blueprint bana raha tha.

Waqt kabhi rukta nahi.

Ye Om ne iss period mein sabse pehle seekha. Din beet-te gaye — ek ke baad ek — aur har din ke saath NEET thodi aur kareeb aati gayi. Coaching mein teachers zyada serious ho gaye. Group mein Tanish bhi thoda zyada padhne laga — Om ki wajah se shayad, ya shayad apni wajah se — par laga.

Gauri ab doosre school mein thi. SUS GC mein kabhi kabhi message aata — koi meme, koi random baat — par ab woh warmth nahi thi jo pehle thi. Doorriyan sirf jagah ki nahi hoti.

Om ne inn sab cheezon ko ek taraf rakh diya.

Pehle kamyabi. Baaki sab baad mein.

NEET ka din aaya.

Om subah utha toh pet mein ek ajeeb si ghutan thi. Haath thode kaanp rahe the. Par usne apna face wash kiya, khaana khaya — do niwale — aur apna admit card uthaya.

Papa ne ek baar pooch liya, "Taiyar ho?"

"Haan Papa."

"Theek se karna."

Bas itna. Par us din Om ko zyada chahiye bhi nahi tha.

Exam hall mein daakhil hote waqt Om ne ek pal ruka. Charo taraf wahi log the — nervous chehere, kaanpte haath, aankhon mein darr. Par Om ko ek ajeeb sa sukoon tha.

Ye meri azaadi ki sabse badi chaabi hai. Aaj ye taala kholna hai.

Usne paper khola. Pehla question padha. Ek gehri saans li. Aur likhna shuru kiya.

Teen ghante baad jab woh hall se bahar nikla, toh usne ek baar bhi peeche mudkar nahi dekha. Koi zaroorat nahi thi — andar jo karna tha, kar aaya tha.

SUS GC mein Tanish ka message aaya — "kaisa gaya bhai??"

Om ne reply kiya — "selection pakka."

Tanish — "bhai confidence dekho 🥺🔥"

Om ne phone rakh diya aur ghar ki taraf chala. Uske qadam mein pehli baar ek alag hi taal thi — na bhaagte hue, na rukke hue. Bas sahi.

Kuch din baad.

Om apne kamre mein tha jab news aaya.

Pehle ek headline dikhi — phir doosri — phir teesri. Sab ek hi baat keh rahe the:

"NEET 2026 Paper Leaked. NTA to conduct re-examination."

Om ne screen ko dekhta raha. Ek baar. Do baar. Teen baar.

Phir usne phone neeche rakh diya.

Kamre mein pankha ghoom raha tha. Bahar chiriya ki awaaz aa rahi thi. Sab kuch bilkul normal tha — jaise duniya ko pata hi nahi tha ki abhi abhi kisi ke paon tale zameen khisak gayi hai.

Re-examination.

Wo sab jo usne kiya tha — wo analysis, wo smartwork, wo teen ghante — sab ek pal mein meaningless ho gaye the. Kisi aur ki galti ki saza wo bhug raha tha.

Om uthke seedha Papa ke paas gaya. Kuch bolna nahi tha — bas jaana tha. Papa ne uski aankhon mein dekha aur samajh gaye.

Unhone kuch nahi kaha. Par pehli baar, Papa ne Om ke kandhe par haath rakha — aur kaha, "Chal. Aaj bahar chalte hain. Mandir ghoom aao. Dimag halka hoga."

Om ne haan kar di.

Mandir mein bheed thi. Ghante ki awaaz thi, dhoop ki khushbu thi, logon ki bheed thi jo apne apne dukh aur apni apni duaayein lekar aaye the.

Om ne bhi haath jode. Aankhein band ki.

Bahar se — bilkul theek tha. Jo baaki log kar rahe the, wahi kar raha tha.

Par andar se?

Andar se wo lad raha tha.

Kyun? Kyun mere saath hi? Maine kya kiya tha? Maine toh sahi kiya tha — smartwork, hardwork, sab kuch. Toh kyun? Agar tu sach mein hai — toh kyun?

Koi jawab nahi aaya. Ghante bajte rahe. Dhoop jalti rahi. Bheed chalti rahi.

Om ne aankhein kholi. Bahar nikla.

Ghar ki taraf waapas aa raha tha jab door se kuch alag dikha.

Pehle usne socha aankhon ka waham hai. Phir usne ruka. Phir usne tez qadam chale.

Phir daud-a.

Unki building nahi thi.

Wahan sirf malaḁa tha — patthar, concrete, lohe ki salaakhein — sab kuch ek doosre ke upar dhera hua. Aas paas log khade the, koi ro raha tha, koi chup tha, koi phone par bol raha tha.

Om ne kisi ke haath pakde — "Kya hua? Ye kaise—"

"Aasmaan mein kuch khula tha — ek laal daraar — usme se chatan giri seedha building par. Poori dhayi gayi. Jo andar the—"

Om ne aage nahi suna.

Uske pair wahan se hil nahi rahe the. Usne malbe ki taraf dekha. Usne socha — Papa wahan the. Maa wahan thi. Unhone kaha tha mandir ghoom aao. Isliye woh zinda tha.

Isliye woh akela tha.

Agle kuch ghante Om ko yaad nahi the. Kaun aaya, kaun gaya, kisne kya kaha — sab dhundla tha. Bas ek cheez yaad thi — ek aurat ne bataya tha ki aisa sirf yahan nahi hua. Poori duniya mein ho raha tha. Wahi laal portals, wahi chataanein, wahi tabahi.

Om ek sunsaan jagah baith gaya. Uske paas kuch nahi tha — ghar nahi, Maa nahi, Papa nahi.

Andar se kuch toot gaya tha — par wo awaaz bhi nahi nikli. Aansu bhi nahi aaye. Bas ek khaali pan tha — itna gehra ki uski koi tah nahi thi.

Ab kya?

Tab uske phone par ek notification aayi.

News alert. Usne open kiya — aur pehli baar us raat uski aankhon mein kuch aaya.

"IKS — Ishaan Kinetic Systems. Grand Inauguration Tomorrow. Ishaan Kumar Singh's biggest venture yet."

Om ne screen ko dekha.

Ishaan. Uska idol. Jisne kaha tha azaadi kamyabi se milti hai. Jisne kaha tha smartwork karo. Jisne khud sab kuch kho ke bhi wapas aaya tha.

Kal. Kal wahan jaana hai.

Shayad koi umeed bachi thi. Ek aakhri.

Agle din Om wahan pahuncha — IKS ki vishaal building ke bahar. Hazaron log the. Cameras the, media thi, excitement thi. Om un sab ke beech khada tha — kapde wohi purane, aankhon mein raat bhar ka khaalipan — par wahan tha.

Stage par Ishaan aaya. Logo ne taaliyaan bajaayi.

Om ne pehli baar apne idol ko itne kareeb se dekha. Wahi thaka hua chehra. Wahi saadgi. Par aankhon mein kuch aisa tha — ek aag — jo Om ne pehle sirf TV par dekhi thi.

Ishaan bolne laga. Microphone ki awaaz poori jagah mein goonji.

Om sun raha tha. Har ek lafz.

Par tabhi —

Bheed mein se kuch log aage aaye. Uniform mein. Haath mein documents.

"Ishaan Kumar Singh — aapko abhi hamare saath aana hoga. Aap par aarop hai ki ye saari tabahi — ye portals, ye mautein — ye sab aapke time travel experiments ka natija hai."

Ek pal ke liye poora maidan khamosh ho gaya.

Phir afra-tafri mach gayi.

Om wahan khada raha — bilkul still — jab Ishaan ko unke beech se le jaaya ja raha tha. Ishaan ne ek baar bheed ki taraf dekha — aur Om ko laga jaise uss nazar mein kuch tha. Koi maafi. Koi dard.

Phir wo chala gaya.

Hazaron log the wahan. Par Om itna akela kabhi nahi tha.

Ghar nahi tha. Maa Papa nahi the. Aur ab Ishaan bhi nahi tha.

Aakhri umeed bhi khatam ho gayi thi.

Om wahan se muda aur chalne laga — bina kisi direction ke, bina kisi manzil ke.



Chapter 4: Sanjivani

Raat gehra chuki thi.

Om chala ja raha tha — bina kisi direction ke, bina kisi manzil ke. Sheher ki sadkein ab bhi zinda thi — gaadiyaan, roshniyan, log — par Om ke liye sab kuch ek dhundli si film ki tarah tha jo koi aur dekh raha ho.

Paon chal rahe the, dimaag nahi.

Pet mein ek ajeeb si jalan thi — do din se kuch nahi khaya tha. Raat ki thandi hawa lag rahi thi par usne notice nahi kiya.

Kuch nahi tha uske paas. Bilkul kuch nahi.

Ek tang gali mein mudre waqt achanak teen chaar saaye aage aa gaye.

"Oye. Ruk."

Om ruka. Unhone use upar neeche dekha.

"Phone nikaal."

Om ne ek pal socha — phir phone haath mein liya. Kya karta. Lad-ta? Kisse? Kyun?

Par jab usne phone aage badhaya, unme se ek ne achanak uske pet mein zor se ghunsa maara. Om dohara ho gaya. Doosre ne phone chheena. Teesre ne uske sar par maara — Om wahan ka wahan gir gaya.

Woh zameen par pada raha. Pet mein aag thi. Sar se kuch garam beh raha tha.

Dard tha — par dard se zyada ek aur cheez thi. Ek thakaan. Itni gehri ki aankhein band karne ko dil karta tha.

Padhe raho. Bas padhe raho.

Wahan aise hi pada raha. Das minute. Shayad zyada. Waqt ka hosh nahi tha.

Tabhi headlights dikhi.

Ek gaadi ruki. Do darwaze khule.

"Om?"

Wo awaaz.

Om ne aankhein kholin — dhundhli nazar mein ek chehra tha. Jaana pehchana. Itne waqt baad bhi jaana pehchana.

Gauri. Aur unke saath — Papa.

Gauri gaadi se nikalte hi seedha uske paas baithi. "Om — ye kya hua? Ye khoon—"

Papa ne aate hi situation samjhi. Woh doosri taraf se Om ko sahara dene lage. "Bete, uth sako? Hospital chalna hai."

"Main theek hoon," Om ne kaha. Awaaz nahi nikli theek se.

"Bilkul theek nahi ho," Gauri ki awaaz kaanp rahi thi par haath stable the. "Uthao inhe Papa."

Dono ne milke Om ko gaadi mein baithaya.

Hospital mein marham paati hui. Sar ka zakhm bandha gaya, pet ka dard kuch kam hua. Nurse ne kuch khane ko diya — dry biscuits, ek glass juice.

Om ne dekha.

Phir usne khaya — aur jaise rok hi nahi paya. Do din ka bhookh ek saath nikal rahi thi. Gauri aur unke Papa wahan baithe dekh rahe the, kuch nahi bole.

Jab Om ruka, toh uske haath kaanp rahe the.

"Do din se kuch nahi khaya tha?" Gauri ne dheere se pooch.

Om ne haan mein sar hilaya.

Papa ne ek doosre ko dekha. Kuch nahi bola kisi ne.

"Chal mere ghar," Gauri ne kaha. "Abhi."

Gauri ke ghar mein roshni thi. Mummy ne darwaza khola — Om ko dekha, uski halat dekhi — aur seedha kitchen ki taraf chali gayi. Koi sawaal nahi. Koi debate nahi.

Gauri ki family Om ko jaanti thi — school ke zamane se. Toh jab wo aaya, toh wo anjaan nahi tha. Wo ek jaana pehchana ladka tha jise kisi ne tod diya tha.

Papa ne sirf itna kaha, "Yahan raho jab tak chahte ho. Koi baat nahi."

Om wahan baitha raha. Ghar ki khushbu thi — khaane ki, agarbatti ki, woh warmth jo sirf tab hoti hai jab koi ghar mein hota hai.

Om ko yaad aaya — uska ghar. Uski building.

Usne aankhein band kar li.

Din beet-te gaye.

Gauri ke ghar mein rehte hue Om ne pehli baar mahsoos kiya ki zindagi abhi khatam nahi hui.

Roz teen waqt ka khaana. Roz ek chhat. Gauri ki Mummy ka wo andaz jisme woh kabhi directly nahi poochti thi par roz kuch na kuch Om ki plate mein extra daal deti thi.

Aur un raaton mein — jab ghar mein sab so jaate — Om ek khaali notebook lekar baith jaata.

Usne naya blueprint banana shuru kiya.

Sab kuch gaya tha — ghar, Maa, Papa — par wo idea nahi gaya tha. Wo toh dimaag mein tha. Usne naye sire se shuru kiya — kagaz par, ek ek line karke.

Ek aisa device jo insaani jism ke kisi bhi baahri zakham ko theek kar sake. 10 minute mein.

Roz raat wo kaam karta. Roz subah ek naya sawaal hota. Roz shaam ek naya jawab.

Aur ek raat, usne socha — SAHAY.

Ishaan ne SAHAY ko poori duniya ke liye open rakha tha. Om ne Gauri ka purana laptop manga — "Ek kaam hai" — aur SAHAY ka interface khola.

"SAHAY," usne dheere se kaha.

"Haan Om. Main hoon," SAHAY ki wahi sukoon bhari awaaz aayi.

Om ek pal ke liye ruk gaya. Itne waqt baad kisi ki awaaz ne use itna kuch feel karaya tha.

"Mujhe ek device banana hai. Teri zaroorat padegi."

"Batao," SAHAY ne kaha. "Main hoon."

9 mahine baad Om ne IKS join kiya.

Aage ki kahani toh duniya jaanti hai — wo safar jo ASCENT mein hua, jo battles hue, jo faislay hue. Ishaan ne jab sab kuch chod diya — apni company, apni technology, apna sab — toh IKS ki kaaman Om ke haath mein aayi.

Kyunki Ishaan ko pata tha — Om samjhega. Om ne jo khokar paya tha, wo koi aur nahi samajh sakta tha.

Cut to: Present.

IKS ka naya hospital.

Bahar hazaron log the. Cameras, media, excitement — wahi sab jo ek baar IKS ke inauguration par tha jab ek tuta hua ladka bheed mein khada apni aakhri umeed dhundh raha tha.

Par aaj wo ladka stage par tha.

Om ne microphone thama. Usne ek baar poori jagah par nazar daali — logo, cameras, log.

"Aaj hum IKS Hospital ka inauguration kar rahe hain," usne kaha. Uski awaaz mein koi excitement nahi thi — sirf ek thanda sa yakeen tha. "Aur aaj hum ek device launch kar rahe hain jo kaafi waqt pehle, ek raat, ek khaali notebook mein bana tha."

Usne ek pause liya.

"Iska naam hai — **Sanjivani.**"

Taaliyaan.

"Ye device insaani jism ke kisi bhi baahri zakham ko 10 minute mein theek kar sakti hai. Ye sirf technology nahi hai. Ye us raat ki yaad hai jab maine khud ye decide kiya tha ki rukna nahi hai."

Bheed khamosh thi. Sunna chahti thi.

Om ne microphone thoda neeche kiya. Uske chehre par ek alag sa expression tha — na garv, na excitement. Sukoon.

"Aur ek aur baat," usne kaha. "Kal se mere ghar ke functions shuru honge. Aur 26 April ko — main aur Gauri — shaadi kar rahe hain."

Pehli baar us speech mein Om muskuraya.

Wahan sab log the — IKS ke log, media, hazaron chehere. Par Om ki nazar sirf ek jagah gayi — pehli row mein, jahan Gauri baithi thi. Software engineer. Jo kabhi ek raat ek tuti hui sadak par ruki thi.

Gauri bhi muskurai.



Chapter 5: The Gods Gift

26 April.

Sheher mein subah se hi ek alag si raunak thi. IKS ki building ke bahar badi badi gaadiyaan aati ja rahi thi. Shamiyana laga hua tha — phool, roshni, dhol ki thaap. Log aa rahe the — bade log, ghar wale, dost, jo log Om ko jaante the aur jo log Om ko sirf naam se jaante the.

Om stage par khada tha. Sherwani mein. Seedha. Shant.

Andar kuch tha jo wo kisi ko nahi dikha sakta tha — ek khaali jagah. Do chehere jo bheed mein nahi the. Jo hote, toh shayad sabse aage hote. Jo hote, toh Papa zaroor kuch na kuch galat karte ceremony mein aur Maa unhe daba ke rakhti.

Par wo nahi the.

Om ne aankhein band ki. Ek pal ke liye.

Tum dekh rahe ho na? Kahi na kahi se?

Koi jawab nahi aaya. Par ek ajeeb sa sukoon tha — jaise jawab ki zaroorat nahi thi.

Varmala ho chuki thi.

Gauri ne jab haar Om ke gale mein daali thi, toh Om ke chehre par jo expression aaya tha — wo usne khud plan nahi kiya tha. Bas aaya tha. Gauri ki aankhon mein bhi kuch tha — wahi jo school ke zamane mein tha, par ab zyada gehra.

Ab pheron ka waqt tha.

Aur beech mein — jaise hamesha hota hai shaadion mein — woh chaos tha. Koi photo kheench raha tha, koi rona raha tha, koi haans raha tha. Koi uncle jo guide kar rahe the ki kaise baithna hai, kaise uthna hai.

Bhuvan aur Mikhail aaye — saath mein unki beti. Mikhail ne Om ko dekh kar ek warm smile di. Bhuvan ne seedha stage par chadh ke Om ko gale lagaya — "Bhai ban gaya tu! Sach mein ban gaya!"

Mikhail ne Gauri ko dekha, phir Om ko, phir muskurai. "Achhi choice hai," usne dheere se kaha — aur pata nahi Gauri ke liye kaha tha ya zindagi ke liye.

Photo kheenchne ka silsila shuru hua. Sabne apni apni baari li — relatives, dost, colleagues.

Tabhi Kenji aaye. Dheere dheere, apni purani chaal se — par unki aankhein wahi thi, tez aur warm.

Unhone Om ko dekha. Phir Gauri ko. Phir unhone sirf itna kaha — "Anjali ko ye pasand aata." Unki awaaz thodi bhaari thi. Bas itna.

Kenji ne Bhuvan ki beti ki taraf dekha — jo unke haath pakde khadi thi.

"Iska naam kya hai?" Kenji ne pooch liya.

Bhuvan ne ek pal muskuraya — wo muskaan jisme garv tha, dard tha, aur ek purani yaad thi.

"Avika," Bhuvan ne kaha. "Ishaan ki yaad mein."

Kenji kuch bol nahi paye. Unhone bas us choti si bachi ko dekha — jo unhe bilkul samajh nahi aa rahi thi ki ye bade log achanak itne chup kyun ho gaye — aur unki aankhein bhar aayi.

Tabhi bahar se ek awaaz aayi.

Kisi ne kaha — "Wo kaali gaadi kaun si hai?"

Phir doosre ne — "Itni badi gaadi... kiska number hai?"

Bheed mein ek halki si halchal hui. Sab confused the.

Gaadi ruki. Kala sheeshe wala darwaza khula.

Aur jo nikla — usse dekh kar Om ki duniya ek pal ke liye tham gayi.

Ishaan.

Wahi thaka hua chehra. Wahi saadgi. Wahi aankhein — jisme ab bhi woh aag thi, par saath mein kuch aur bhi tha. Kuch jo pehle nahi tha.

Bheed ne rasta diya — khud ba khud — jaise logon ko pata tha ki ye insaan stage tak pahunchega aur koi rok nahi sakta.

Ishaan stage par aaya. Usne Om ko dekha. Om ne use dekha.

Koi lafz nahi the is waqt ke liye.

Ishaan ne pehle Gauri ko dekha — ek nazar, ek muskaan — phir wapas Om ki taraf.

"OG photo," Ishaan ne sirf itna kaha.

Sab ek saath aye — Ishaan, Om, Gauri, Bhuvan, Mikhail, Kenji. Bhuvan ki beti Avika Mikhail ki god mein thi.

Photographer ne sabko arrange kiya. Sab khade the — alag alag heights, alag alag chehere — par ek hi frame mein.

Photo kheenchi gayi.

Om ne ek pal us frame ko mehsoos kiya — ye log, ye pal. Avika nahi thi — par uska naam tha. Uski jagah thi — Gauri ki aankhon mein, Bhuvan ki beti ke naam mein, Kenji ki khamoshi mein.

Kuch cheezein jaati nahi. Bas badal jaati hain.

Photo ke baad Ishaan Om ke paas aaya. Usne apni jacket ki andar ki pocket se ek dabba nikala — chhota, saada, koi ribbon nahi.

"Gift," usne kaha.

Om ne liya. "Abhi kholunga baad mein—"

"Nahi," Ishaan ne kaha. "Abhi nahi kholna. Baad mein."

Om ne haan kar di.

Ishaan ne ek pal Om ki aankhon mein dekha — aur phir dheere se, bilkul seedha, bola:

"Shayad ye aakhri baar hai ki tum mujhe dekh rahe ho. Iske baad mujhe dhundhne ki koshish mat karna. Aur karoge bhi... toh dhundh nahi paoge."

Om ke gale mein kuch atak gaya. "Ishaan—"

Par Ishaan wapas mud chuka tha. Bheed ne phir rasta diya. Kaali gaadi ka darwaza khula. Band hua.

Gaadi chali gayi.

Om wahan khada raha — shehnai ki awaaz thi, dhol ki thaap thi, log haans rahe the, bol rahe the — sab kuch chal raha tha. Par Om ek pal ke liye wahan nahi tha.

Gauri ne uska haath pakda. Om wapas aaya.

Pheron ke baad jab raat ko gifts khole ja rahe the, tab Om ko Ishaan wala dabba yaad aaya.

Usne khola.

Andar ek kada tha — dhatu ka, saada, par usmein ek ajeeb sa patthar jada hua tha. Na heera, na neelam, na koi jaana pehchana gem — kuch aur. Ek aisi roshni thi usme jo na poori chamakti thi, na poori bujhti thi. Bas thi.

Om ne use haath mein liya. Thanda tha — par jaise hi usne pehna, ek halki si warmth aayi.

Usne kada apni kalai par pehna liya.

Gauri ne dekha. "Kiska gift hai?"

"Ishaan ka," Om ne kaha.

Gauri ne kada dekha — phir Om ka chehra dekha. Kuch nahi boli.

Om ne bhi kuch nahi kaha.

Wo gem kya thi — ye kisi ko nahi pata tha. Par ek baat thi jo Om ko mehsoos ho rahi thi — ye cheez sirf zevar nahi hai. Ye kuch aur hai.

Kya — wo aage pata chalega.

